

Chapter 157-2

After Zhao Xuning tidied up the house, she sat on the living room sofa and played on her phone for a while, then went to the master bedroom bathroom to take a shower. She also took a brand new set of toiletries from the storage room and placed them in the outer washroom, sticking a note on the door to remind Liang Shi where everything was.

She put on simple makeup, grabbed her bag, and headed out.

This trip home was probably going to be about the matchmaking issue again, which was nothing new for Zhao Xuning.

And she already had a mature set of responses to deal with it.

She had no plans to go on blind dates, nor did she plan to get married.

At least not at this stage.

After breaking up with Shen Hui, she had briefly wanted to meet new people and start new relationships to distract herself.

But she later discovered that no one compared to Shen Hui.

So she cut off any ambiguous relationships with others and never had such thoughts again.

She used to always hear people say that after a breakup, you just need to find someone new and you'll be fine.

But after Zhao Xuning tried it herself, she realized that when it came to matters of the heart, it was like a fish drinking water—only the fish knows whether it's cold or warm.¹

Being in contact with new people wouldn't fill the emptiness in her heart.

On the contrary, it only made her miss the past even more.

No matter which street she walked down or which star she saw, she would always think of those past memories.

And then find the current person even more boring.

She had spent many years building rapport with Shen Hui.

All those memories were incredibly precious.

The thought of dating someone else made her feel completely uncomfortable.

So eventually, she let go of others, and also let go of herself.

Zhao Xuning drove back home. There were quite a lot of people there—it was a family gathering. Not only was her sister there, but Zhao Ying and Zhao Ling were there too.

Their family was quite large, with seven or eight people in her generation, half of whom were already married.

Zhao Xuning wasn't actually that old, but because she had skipped grades and started working very quickly, people had the impression that she was older.

While eating at the table, an elder even asked her how old she was in her thirties this year.

Zhao Xuning paused and answered coldly: "Twenty-five."

"That's still young." The elder said. "But it's already time to start dating. Date for two years, get married, and you should have children early."

Zhao Xuning had gotten used to hearing this kind of thing. She ate quietly, but when she heard the words "children," her hand gripping the chopsticks suddenly tightened. Her throat felt itchy for an instant, and she turned her head to cough.

Zhao Ying, who was sitting beside her, came to her rescue: "What's the rush? We're still young."

"You're still young?" Zhao Ying's mother suddenly spoke up, her tone chilly. "You're almost thirty. By the way, are you and Yang Shuyan really together? I saw online that you two are dating?"

Zhao Ying was instantly stunned speechless.²

Meanwhile, Zhao Ling lowered her head, trying to hold back her laughter.

"That's not true at all." Zhao Ying waved her hand, lying without batting an eye. "Those are just marketing accounts making things up. Yang Shuyan's fans and I have been at each other's throats—why would I be with her?"

Zhao Ying's mother poked Zhao Ying's head: "Don't let your uncles and aunties see you as a joke. You're always hyping up CP ships³ online, and none of them are real."

Zhao Ying: "..."

"Xi Pi"⁴ means CP.

Mrs. Zhao, who was obsessed with playing cards and ballroom dancing, only half-understood entertainment industry terminology. She said it with a straight face, but Zhao Ying explained: "That's all just for work. I'm not close with any of them."

"Then who are you close with?" Mrs. Zhao asked. "Last time I asked you to get an autograph from that person, you also said you weren't close with them, even though you've clearly been photographed together."

"Which person?" Zhao Ying asked.

Mrs. Zhao paused: "The one from that period drama before, that really handsome guy..."

"Mom, he's been arrested for soliciting prostitutes." Zhao Ying said. "If I were close with him, wouldn't my career be ruined?"⁵

Mrs. Zhao: "...You're useless."

Zhao Ying was speechless.

But she and her mom were often like this—they'd have a battle of three hundred rounds over nothing, and neither could win in a war of words.

They argued earnestly and intensely, drawing all the attention that had been focused on Zhao Xuning over to themselves.

So Zhao Xuning ate quietly.

But what was meant to come would eventually come. After the meal, she had just picked up her car keys, planning to make an excuse about having something at the hospital and leave, when her father called out to her.

"Come here." Father Zhao called to her seriously. "I need to talk to you about something."

Zhao Xuning paused. "I have things to do."

Father Zhao looked at her coldly: "You can do them after I'm done talking with you."

Zhao Xuning held her keys and followed him upstairs.

In the study, her mother and sister were also there.

"The people here." Father Zhao got straight to the point as soon as he entered. "Pick one."

It seemed less like picking a person and more like picking cabbage at the market.

Zhao Xuning frowned and glanced at the roster that had at least a dozen pages. "I'm not going."

"I'm not asking you to go on a blind date." Father Zhao said. "Pick one to get to know, and get married next year."

Zhao Xuning: "..."

Even more rushed than before.

Zhao Xuning exhaled lightly. "What do you mean?"

"Your sister had already given birth to Lianlian at your age." Father Zhao said. "Look at you—all you do is hospital, home, hospital, home. How are you supposed to date like this? Forget dating. It's not going to work out anyway. Just pick one and get married."

Zhao Xuning: "..."

"Impossible." Zhao Xuning refused. "I'm not getting married."

"Are you still in contact with that girl from before?" Father Zhao was suddenly alert, his brow furrowing. "The one you dated in university, the one you said you wanted to marry... You two haven't broken up?"

Zhao Xuning: "..."

"We broke up." Zhao Xuning said.

"Then that's fine." Father Zhao said. "It's not about whether she was good enough for you or not. The main thing is that the gap between you two was too big. Zhao Xuning, you need to understand that when it comes to your marriage, you can't be willful."

When it came to her major and marriage, Zhao Xuning only had one choice of freedom.

She had given up the Zhao family's business to her sister and chosen the major she liked.

In marriage, she had lost the initiative.

Her marriage had to contribute to the Zhao family and stabilize the Zhao family's company.

This was something Zhao Xuning had known for a long time.

So she had never planned to date. Meeting Shen Hui... was an accident.

This accident had caused her to have a huge fight with her family, and the longest she went without coming home was nearly half a year.

At that time, her sister came as a mediator. It also happened to be near the time she was applying to graduate school abroad, so using the excuse that she was still young, these matters were suppressed and no one mentioned them.

Most crucially, her father had investigated Shen Hui's identity, but only found the fabricated layer that the Shen family had created for Shen Hui.

Her sister only knew because when those events happened, her sister happened to be on a business trip there.

At that time, her sister had advised her not to be too stubborn—going against their father wouldn't end well.

But later, seeing her persistence, her sister had switched sides and said she would try to persuade their father.

But unexpectedly, that time, Shen Fenghe slapped her at the hospital.

And her sister had been standing not far away.

Afterward, her sister confronted Shen Fenghe at the hospital.

Thinking back on what happened that day was like a nightmare.

Now that her father was bringing up old matters, Zhao Xuning stood there feeling a terrible headache, as if millions of ants were biting her.

She furrowed her brow tightly, radiating impatience from her entire body.

1. This is a Chinese idiom (如鱼饮水，冷暖自知) meaning that only the person experiencing something truly knows how it feels—like a fish drinking water, only it knows whether the water is cold or warm. It expresses that emotional experiences are deeply personal and cannot be fully understood by outsiders. ⇐
2. The original Chinese slang "蚌住" (bàng zhù) is internet slang meaning to be so shocked or embarrassed that one is rendered speechless, like a clam snapping shut. ⇐
3. CP (Couple Pairing) refers to the practice of fans "shipping" or supporting romantic pairings between celebrities, whether real or imagined. "Hyping up CP ships" refers to deliberately creating or promoting such pairings for marketing purposes. ⇐
4. "西皮" (xī pí) is a transliteration of "CP" using Chinese characters that sound similar. Mrs. Zhao uses this term showing she's somewhat aware of entertainment industry terminology but not fully fluent in it. ⇐
5. The phrase "凉了" (liáng le, literally "gone cold") is Chinese entertainment industry slang meaning a celebrity's career has become inactive or ruined due to scandal or other issues. ⇐